

WORD STRESS

Word stress means giving more emphasis (strength) to one syllable in a word.

The stressed syllable is said louder, longer, and clearer than the others.

Why word stress is important

It helps people understand you clearly

Wrong stress can change meaning or sound incorrect in English

Examples

TAble → /ˈteɪ.bəl/

aBOUt → /əˈbaʊt/

DOctor → /ˈdɒk.tər/

(👉 Capital letters show the stressed syllable)

Types / Rules of Word Stress

1. Two-syllable nouns & adjectives

Stress is usually on the first syllable

PREsent (noun)

HAPpy

TAble

2. Two-syllable verbs & prepositions

Stress is usually on the second syllable

preSENT (verb)

reLAX

aBOVE

3. Words ending in -tion, -sion

Stress is on the syllable before the ending

eduCAtion

disCUSSION

4. Words ending in -ic, -ical

Stress comes before the ending

geoGRAPHic

POLitical

Stress can change meaning

PREsent (gift – noun)

preSENT (to give – verb)

Simple practice

Say these aloud:

COMfort

imPORTant

TEAcher